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JOB SEEKER SURVIVAL GUIDE

How to Navigate the Modern Job Search Without Losing Your Mind

Applications. LinkedIn. Recruiters. Interviews. Ghosting. AI.

Let's make this whole thing make a little more sense.

INSIDE

7 recruiter-backed survival rules + the 15-minute job application check

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The job search is weird right now.

If you've been applying to jobs and wondering whether you're doing something wrong, welcome to the modern job search.

There are hundreds of applicants. AI-generated everything. Job descriptions asking for 14 skills for a role that somehow still pays \$65K. Recruiters who reach out and disappear. Companies that put you through six interviews. And rejection emails that arrive approximately four months after you forgot you applied.

It's a lot.

But here's what I want you to know:

- ✓ You do not need to apply to 100 jobs a week.
- ✓ You do not need to completely rewrite your resume every time you apply.
- ✓ You do not need to spend your entire day on LinkedIn.
- ✓ And you definitely do not need to turn the job search into your entire personality.

You need a strategy.

I've spent nearly a decade recruiting, reviewing resumes, interviewing candidates and watching hiring decisions happen from the other side of the table.

This guide is the stuff I wish every job seeker knew before they hit Apply.

Let's get into it.

Stop measuring your job search by how many jobs you apply to.

There is nothing inherently impressive about submitting 75 applications.

If 70 of them are jobs you're barely qualified for, don't actually want or applied to without taking five minutes to understand the company, you're creating activity, not necessarily progress.

You don't need to check every single box in a job description. You do need to make enough sense on paper that someone wants to learn more.

Quick check:

- ✓ Am I genuinely qualified for most of what they're asking for?
- ✓ Would I actually accept an interview for this job?
- ✓ Can I clearly explain why my experience connects to this role?
- ✓ Is my resume making that connection obvious?

JGO REALITY CHECK

10 thoughtful applications can be more valuable than 100 random ones. Your goal isn't to win LinkedIn's imaginary award for Most Applications Submitted. Your goal is to get hired.

Your resume has one job.

And no, its job is not to tell your entire life story.

Its job is to make someone think: “I want to talk to this person.” That’s it.

A recruiter may initially look at your resume for seconds, not minutes. Make those seconds easy.

Your resume does not need an objective explaining that you are “seeking a challenging opportunity to utilize your skills.” I promise. We know why you’re here.

It also doesn’t need six lines describing every responsibility you have ever had since 2011. Focus on what matters now.

Quick check:

- ✓ Top third: Can I immediately tell what you do?
- ✓ Recent experience: Is the most relevant information easy to find?
- ✓ Bullets: Do they show impact, ownership or results instead of just listing tasks?
- ✓ Keywords: Am I naturally using language relevant to the role?
- ✓ Formatting: Can a human being actually read this thing?

JGO REALITY CHECK

If the answer is yes, stop editing it for the 47th time.

Please stop trying to beat the ATS.

Somewhere along the way, job seekers became convinced there is a mysterious robot standing between them and employment.

Applicant tracking systems are real. But stuffing your resume with invisible keywords, copying an entire job description into the footer or asking AI to turn every sentence into corporate word salad is not the strategy.

Think alignment, not gaming the system.

If a role repeatedly asks for Project Management, Stakeholder Management, Salesforce and B2B SaaS, and you genuinely have that experience, those things should probably be easy to find on your resume.

JGO REALITY CHECK

That's not tricking an ATS. That's communicating clearly.

LinkedIn is part of your resume now.

Someone is probably going to look you up. Make sure what they find supports the story your resume is telling.

And please make sure your LinkedIn dates and resume dates match. Recruiters notice.

Quick check:

- ✓ Photo: Current, clear and professional.
- ✓ Headline: Tell me what you do. You have more space than just your current job title.
- ✓ About: Give me context. Who are you professionally? What are you great at? What kind of problems do you solve?
- ✓ Experience: It should generally align with your resume.
- ✓ Skills: Use them.

JGO REALITY CHECK

You do not need to become a LinkedIn influencer. You can simply have a strong profile, engage thoughtfully and connect with people in your industry.

Applying is only one lane of the job search.

Yes, apply to jobs. But also reconnect with former coworkers. Message people you genuinely know. Talk to recruiters. Follow companies you care about. Reach out thoughtfully when you see a strong connection. Tell people you're looking.

A surprising number of job seekers quietly search for six months while telling approximately nobody.

You don't need to announce your job search to the entire internet. But people cannot help you if they don't know you're looking.

REMEMBER

Try this: "Hey! I'm starting to explore new opportunities in [AREA]. If you happen to hear of anything that feels aligned with my background in [X/Y], I'd love to be on your radar." Normal. Human. No awkward begging required.

Getting the interview is not the finish line.

If you're getting interviews but not offers, that is actually useful information. Your resume is probably doing its job. Now we look at the interview.

One of the biggest mistakes candidates make is preparing to answer questions instead of preparing to tell their story.

You cannot predict every question. You can prepare the stories you want to tell.

Quick check:

- ✓ Why this company?
- ✓ Why this role?
- ✓ Why now?
- ✓ What are the 4–5 experiences you absolutely want them to know about?
- ✓ What examples prove you can do what this job requires?

REMEMBER

Have questions. Not because somebody told you that you have to ask questions at the end. Ask because you are interviewing them too.

Use AI. Just don't let AI turn you into a robot.

AI can be incredibly helpful during a job search. Use it to compare your resume to a job description, brainstorm interview questions, practice answers, research what you should understand before an interview, organize your accomplishments, improve clarity and get unstuck.

But if your cover letter begins: "I am writing to express my enthusiastic interest in the esteemed position..." We have a problem.

You should still sound like you.

REMEMBER

AI should help you communicate your experience. It should not invent your experience, inflate your skills or make you sound like a management consultant who swallowed a thesaurus.

Before you hit Apply.

You do not need a two-hour resume rewrite every single time. Use this instead.

2 MINUTES	Read the actual job description.
3 MINUTES	Identify the 3–5 things they seem to care about most.
5 MINUTES	Look at your resume. Are those things obvious if you genuinely have them?
2 MINUTES	Check the company and role on LinkedIn.
2 MINUTES	Look for a relevant connection, recruiter or hiring team member.
1 MINUTE	Proofread.

THEN APPLY.

No two-hour resume rewrite required.

Come back to this.

- ✓ You don't need to apply to everything.
- ✓ You don't need to follow every piece of career advice on the internet.
- ✓ You don't need to completely reinvent yourself.
- ✓ And you don't need to interpret every rejection as proof that your career is doomed.

You need:

- ✓ A clear story.
- ✓ A strong resume.
- ✓ Intentional applications.
- ✓ Good interview preparation.
- ✓ Some actual human connection.
- ✓ And enough patience to stay consistent.

The modern job search can be chaotic.

Your strategy doesn't have to be.

OKAY. NOW WHAT?

Pick one thing.

Pick one thing from this guide that you know you need to work on. Not eight. One.

Fix that first. Then keep going.

And if you want someone who has actually sat on the recruiting side of the table to help you figure out what isn't working, that's literally what I do.

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Career coaching from a career coach + recruiter.

Resume Strategy • Interview Coaching • Job Search Strategy • LinkedIn Optimization • Career Coaching

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